



Airport design

Early airports were simple in shape with a single building in an airfield. Several key configurations have since been used that are designed to allow ample space for planes to land and take off and to provide for the comfort of passengers. One of the most common is the satellite design, which has a central building surrounded by a number of smaller structures with aircraft clustered around them. Gatwick Airport in London and Paris-Charles de Gaulle Airport are examples of circular satellite designs. Pier designs, featuring a linear or curvilinear building with aircraft parked on both sides, are also frequently used. Less commonly, some airports use mobile lounges that transport passengers from a central building directly to their plane.

PARIS-CHARLES DE GAULLE

An architectural wonder, Charles de Gaulle Airport in Paris has three terminals. Terminal One, designed by French architect Paul Andreu, is a complex circular building with seven satellites designed to allow numerous planes to park. The satellites have multiple levels of waiting rooms, baggage handling, and shopping areas. A radical, beautiful design for its time, it is now limited by its inability to expand to accommodate more flights. Terminal Two has a central corridor off which seven smaller terminals are positioned, allowing the opportunity for future expansion. Terminal Three is far simpler, with a single hall.

This aerial view of Paris-Charles de Gaulle Airport shows the circular design of Terminal One, with its seven terminals around a central hub.